hurry, to wait, as he said ‘I can’t reach the commander,’ ” recalled Serovoi.[14]

When General Garbuz arrived at the headquarters, Grechko informed him that “[a] ‘guest’ has been circling around us for more than an hour. I think the order has to be given to shoot down the American plane because it can discover our positions to their fullest extent, and the reconnaissance data will be known to Washington in a few hours.” Both generals knew that Pliev issued a prohibition against shooting at the American planes without his direct orders, but he was not around and out of reach. Grechko consulted with his other deputies. Most of them were missile officers who considered Pliev, as a former cavalryman, a poor fit for the job, since he knew nothing about missiles. They all were in favor of shooting down the plane. Garbuz told Grechko: “[A]ll the missile starts have now been ‘lit up,’ and the secret information cannot be allowed to make its way to the Pentagon.”

Grechko probably felt that the decision was now up to him, since air defense was his responsibility. A veteran of World War II who had seen a great deal of fighting on the German front, Grechko knew that reconnaissance flights of enemy airplanes would be followed by bombing. He had been wounded in 1943 in the course of a German attack on the headquarters of the army group to which he had been assigned. Grechko belonged to an elite group of Soviet commanders closely associated personally with Nikita Khrushchev. These included the former commander of strategic missile forces, Marshal Kirill Moskalenko, and Grechko’s direct superior in the Moscow air defense district, General Pavel Batitsky, who had personally shot Khrushchev’s archrival, Lavrentii Beria, in December 1953. Dispatched to Cuba directly from Moscow, while the others had come from the Soviet provinces, Grechko had more clout than other deputies of Pliev.[15]

After “the radar man said he would go back to Guantánamo in five minutes,” recalled Garbuz, “Grechko said, ‘I have made a decision to shoot him down.’ ” He added to Garbuz: “I guess we’ll both answer for it.” Garbuz agreed. “We both were responsible,” he admitted decades later. In Camagüey Major Serovoi received the order to open fire from the commander of his division, Colonel Voronkov, who never told Serovoi who had given the order; Serovoi believed that Voronkov had issued it on his